Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list “indigo = this”, and yet some meanings repeat surprisingly often. They are usually made up of three layers, **the body**, **culture** and **what we have lived through ourselves**.

From the body

Indigo is the colour of **dusk** and **deep night**. When it gets dark, light fades and the eyes adjust. The world calms and loses detail. Indigo says. **Now is the time to be still and look inward.** At the same time, though, the body naturally links dark colours with uncertainty, and so it can sometimes be oppressive too.

From culture

Indigo is worn in jeans, uniforms and evening dresses. It is the colour of depth, expertise and mystery, but also the colour of work. The same colour that a labourer wears in overalls decorates the packaging of luxury goods. **It depends on where we grew up.** In the section on cultures we will look at this in more detail, because indigo also carries heavy stories.

From what you have lived

Favourite jeans, the night sky above a country cottage, a school uniform, a dark blue coat from mum, an evening bus. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same indigo** and one feels calm, the other uncertainty. The colour is the same. The story is not.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is “indigo” and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What comes to mind first when I see a woman in an indigo coat or a man in a dark blue shirt?**

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Stories

A colour that is from India

The word indigo comes from the Latin **indicum** and the Greek indikon, that is “Indian”. The dye was imported to Europe from India and as the name of a colour it is first attested in English in **1289**. The name of the colour is the name of the country it came from. The dye is obtained mainly from the plant **Indigofera tinctoria**, in Europe a similar blue was obtained from woad (Isatis tinctoria).

Newton and the seven colours

Isaac Newton distinguished seven colours in the rainbow and linked them with the seven tones of the musical scale. He himself, though, wrote that colours pass smoothly one into another, so the number seven was **his choice**, not a physical fact. Some researchers think that Newton's “indigo” is what we now call blue, others reject this. Indigo is thus partly **a musical decision**.

Blue gold and its price

Indigo was for a long time rare and expensive. Behind its beauty, though, were heavy stories. On plantations in America, for example in South Carolina, in Haiti and in Jamaica, it was grown using **the labour of enslaved people**. In India the Bengal uprising against the exploitation by European planters arose in 1859 and the play Nil Darpan tells of it. In 1917 a wave of resistance rose in the Champaran region of Bihar. Peasants were obliged to sow part of their land with indigo. **Gandhi** went there to investigate their complaints and when the authorities ordered him to leave, he refused. It was his first act of civil disobedience in India. A colour of beauty often stood on work that was not beautiful.

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